election held soon after the Emergency was lifted. She stormed back to power in the 1980 general election, with the Congress winning 353 seats. So, like her father Nehru, Indira, too, led the Congress to three general election wins with majorities, but not one after the other as he did.

Other findings in the current MOTN survey reaffirm that Modi and the BJP are on track to achieve electoral fame. One barometer is how those surveyed rate Modi's performance as prime minister in his 10th year in office. As many as 60.5 per cent of the respondents consider it good or outstanding, with only 23.6 per cent putting it in the poor to very poor category. Though a drop of 2.2 percentage points from the August 2023 MOTN, the over 60 per cent rating is commendable, given the multiple major crises Modi has had to tackle in his second term, including a once-in-a-century pandemic that precipitated an economic collapse made more fraught by a global slowdown. Two major wars—one in Ukraine and the other in Gaza—fuelled inflation. In sharp contrast, only 26 per cent of those polled in the 10th year of Manmohan Singh's tenure as PM rated his performance as good (there was no rating for outstanding at the time) in the MOTN of January 2014 and a massive 67 per cent gave him average to poor ratings. Even the NDA government's ratings are at an impressive 55.9 per cent in the current MOTN, despite the 12.8 percentage point drop from 67.1 per cent in January 2023.

MODI MANIA

What the current MOTN also reflects clearly is the TINA (There is No Alternative) factor at work. The acronym, in fact, has now metamorphosed into TIMO or There is Modi Only. This can be gauged by the responses to just one question in the MOTN survey: who is best suited to be the next prime minister. In the August 2021 MOTN in the midst of the Covid wave, Modi's ratings had dropped precipitously to just 24 per cent, from the stratospheric 66 per cent after the first year of his second term that began in 2019.

They have shot up in five successive MOTNs since, hovering above the 50 per cent mark, with the latest at 54.9 per cent, an improvement of 2.6 percentage points over the August 2023 MOTN. Significantly, the gap between Modi and Rahul Gandhi, his prime challenger, which had narrowed to just 14 percentage points in August 2021, has widened to a Grand Canyon of 41.1 percentage points.

Indeed, the current MOTN holds little cheer for Rahul Gandhi, the

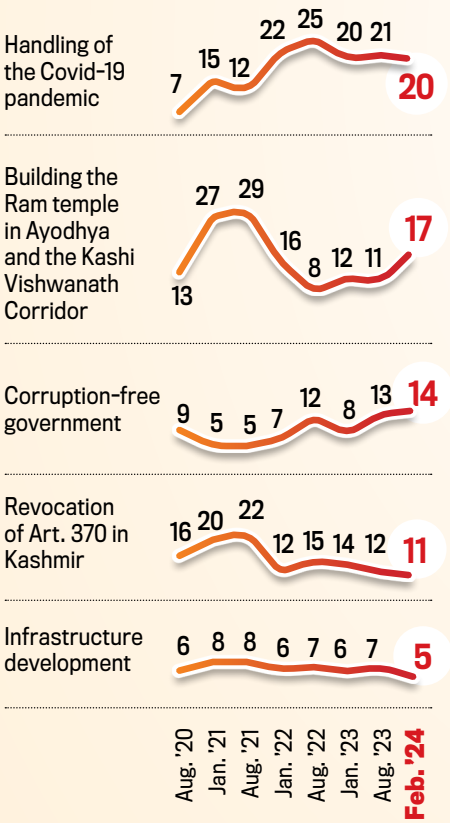


AFP

Q. How would you rate Narendra Modi's performance as prime minister?



Q. What in your view is the single biggest achievement of the NDA government?



Rest, others & DK/ CS

More respondents feel fighting Covid was a bigger achievement than building the Ram temple